

shouting slogans occasionally.

A smiling Jalan asked tea to be served to them. As they settled down, Jalan called [Alpana] Killawala, the RBI's communications chief, and asked her to get the press release. It was prepared even before the meeting took place! The three AIBEA office-bearers looked at each other.

Jalan gave a cursory glance at the release that Killawala had brought and then passed that on to Chakraborty, seeking his nod, "Is this okay?" Chakraborty couldn't believe his eyes. The release said the RBI governor had a constructive discussion with the AIBEA leader, who had agreed to withdraw the strike on assurance from the governor that the central bank would look into their demands! Chakraborty passed on the release to his comrades.

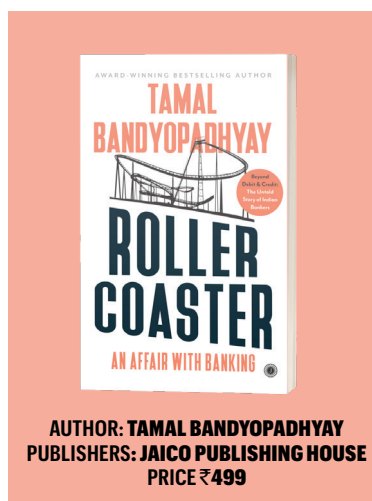
Jalan was straightforward in his approach. "I must say I will look into your demands. Otherwise, you cannot withdraw the strike call. What will you tell your colleagues waiting outside the RBI gate? You're not going ahead with the strike. I must assure you that we will look into the issues. Where's the confusion?" The message was clear. Chakraborty got up, shook hands, and left.

One of the contributing factors to Jalan's superb handling of Chakraborty was probably his relationship with West Bengal Chief Minister Jyoti Basu. Jalan introduced the clean note policy. It began with a hugely successful "coin mela" introduced by Jaganmohan Rao, a deputy general manager at Chandigarh.

Jalan also introduced the Currency Verification and Processing System in the central bank for faster and more secure processing of soiled currency notes. Weeding out soiled currency notes and replacing them with fresh ones was part of the clean note policy he championed. Until then, thousands of RBI employees were stapling fresh notes and counting soiled notes before destroying them. One morning, Jalan and the

team led by Deputy Governor Vepa Kamesan checked whether banks counted those notes before sending them to the RBI. They were. Had there been any discrepancy in counting between the RBI and the banks? No. So, why do the same job twice?

Jalan told the people to sit at home and earn their salary, doing nothing. They would get their increments. They could even drop by for lunch at the RBI canteen if they wished. That's how he changed the ratio of clerks and officers. Officially,



it was done through an early retirement scheme, the first of its kind at the RBI. Till such time, sub-staff and clerks dominated the RBI, and the percentage of officers was meagre. Among 40,000 employees, 34,000 belonged to the first two categories, and they were all unionised.

In many ways, Jalan demystified the 18th floor of the RBI, the governor's domain. He was the first governor to walk into any deputy governor's cabin (housed on the 18th floor, then) unannounced. Anytime.

Such visits made Reddy quit smoking! In a closed air-conditioned room, however large it is, the smell won't go away. Reddy preferred to quit smoking rather than get caught by Jalan. Of course, he did not give up without a fight! Reddy did try to

take smoking breaks in the stairwell landing before calling it quits.

Jalan also did not like heaps of files piling up on his table. From about 80 files a day, he cut the number to five—only those the governor must go through. In addition, the files already cleared by deputy governors and sent to him "for information" were stopped at his executive assistant's table. The same process followed for books. There was a never-ending flow of books into the governor's room. Jalan would send them back to his office with three tags—D (for destruction), L (for library), and TiH (take it home).

He would take a close look at all and read some of them. He would keep notes on a card for each important book he had read and would like to refer to in the future. All the cards were alphabetically arranged in a row of 5"x4" wooden boxes on his table. Jalan was not very fond of giving speeches. On very few occasions when he did, he would prepare meticulously but might not necessarily stick to the script already printed and distributed. Besides, there were a few commitments that he could not dodge. Those speeches were all extempore.

He replicated the book policy for the speeches. He had different reasons for declining to give a speech. They were listed and kept for his office under some 20 heads—from A to T. A would say how grateful he was for the opportunity to address such an august audience, but unfortunately, he could not accept it because of a commitment already made. B would wish great success to the event, adding it would be his loss for not being able to make it. So on. Jalan would direct his office to use A, B, C, or some other letter for declining the invitation, depending on who was organising it. **BT**

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